“I must give people whatever they ask of me.”

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Where it often comes from

Generous people, caregivers, and helpers can be asked for time, money, rides, listening, and favors without end. If we were raised to think that refusing a request is unloving, we can end up drained and used. Some of us also feel that if someone is in need, we are automatically responsible.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes of giving, “Each one should give what he has decided in his heart to give, not out of regret or compulsion. For God loves a cheerful giver.” He also says, “Each one should carry his own load.” Proverbs notes, “The prudent man watches his steps.” Jesus said, “Let your ‘Yes’ be ‘Yes,’ and your ‘No,’ ‘No.’” Giving is a gift of the heart. It is not a duty to anyone who asks. We are called to love, and love uses wisdom: sometimes it gives, sometimes it says no, and sometimes it points to other resources.

> *“Each one should give what he has decided in his heart to give, not out of regret or compulsion. For God loves a cheerful giver”* (2 Corinthians 9:7).

Also see

> “For each one should carry his own load” (Galatians 6:5).

> “The simple man believes every word, but the prudent man watches his steps” (Proverbs 14:15).

> “Simply let your ‘Yes’ be ‘Yes,’ and your ‘No,’ ‘No.’ Anything more comes from the evil one” (Matthew 5:37).

> “Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ” (Galatians 1:10).

Common self-statements

- If someone asks, I have to say yes.
- I cannot say no to people in need.
- Refusing is unloving.
- I must meet every request.
- If I do not help, no one will.
- I owe everyone my time.

Common logical errors

- Should statements: Insisting that I must meet every request.
- Personalization: Treating every need as my responsibility.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must give everything or nothing.
- Magnification: Treating a refusal as cruelty.

Challenging questions

- What do people ask of me that leaves me resentful?
- Do I give out of cheerful choice or compulsion?

- What are my real limits in time, money, and energy?
- What are other resources the person could use?
- How can I say no with kindness?
- What would giving freely look like?

Truth summary

> I am free to decide what I give. God loves a cheerful giver, not a compelled one. I can say yes with joy when I can, say no with kindness when I cannot, and trust God to care for those I cannot help.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Giving
- Servant
- Wisdom
- Tired
- Love, For Others

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Weak/Tired
- Communication

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "I must give people whatever they ask of me"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must give people whatever they ask of me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What requests drain me?
- ☐ Do I give gladly or by compulsion?
- ☐ What are my limits?
- ☐ What other resources exist?
- ☐ How can I say no kindly?
- ☐ What can I give freely?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God loves a cheerful giver.
- ☐ I decide in my heart what to give.
- ☐ Compulsion is not love.
- ☐ I carry my own load.
- ☐ The prudent watch their steps.
- ☐ I can trust God with others' needs.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 2 Corinthians 9:7
  "Each one should give what he has decided in his heart to give, not out of regret or compulsion. For God loves a cheerful giver."
- ☐ Galatians 6:5
  "For each one should carry his own load."
- ☐ Matthew 5:37
  "Simply let your 'Yes' be 'Yes,' and your 'No,' 'No.' Anything more comes from the evil one."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Chosen giving: Each week, record one thing you gave gladly and one request you declined kindly.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 2 Corinthians 9:7 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I decide in my heart what to give, and God loves a cheerful giver.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Giving" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] List the drains. Write the requests that leave you resentful.
- [ ] Define your limits. Decide what you can give in time and money.
- [ ] Practice a response. Write, "I can't, but I hope you find help."
- [ ] Give gladly. Choose one thing to give freely this week.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must give people whatever they ask of me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Chosen giving
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must give people whatever they ask of me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I want to be generous, but I am worn out. Teach me to give freely and wisely, to say no kindly, and to trust You with the needs I cannot meet. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.